

Discover handwriting recognition

We explore a lesser-known feature in Vista that can turn your handwriting into type

Many people find typing to be a slow, frustrating process. However, if you have a tablet PC or a graphics tablet with a stylus, there is another means of inputting available to you.

You might not know it, but Windows Vista supports handwriting recognition. Handwriting recognition is not a new technology, but it has come a long way in recent times. Although handwriting recognition is particularly useful for tablet PC users (which come with touch-sensitive screens), the simple and cheap addition of a graphics tablet to any computer — be it a laptop or desktop machine — can provide the same feature without the need for a special display.

Step 1

If you are using a tablet PC, or have installed a graphics tablet, the Tablet PC input panel should be displayed automatically. If this is not the case, click Start, type **tablet** and click the **Tablet PC Input Panel** link in the results that are displayed. The first thing to do is choose how the panel should be displayed. Click the **Tools** menu and choose between floating anywhere on-screen, or docked at the top or bottom of the screen. When writing in the panel, clicking the **Insert** button adds the writing that has been converted into text into the current document or text field. By default it appears on the right of the screen, but this can be changed by clicking **Tools > Option** and choosing the **Left** option if desired.

